THE HOUSE OF IDEAS

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

“THE ROOF”

July 18 – December 2, 2013
San Diego • Greenwich • Leicester Square • Los Feliz

An Alternate-History Hollywood Saga

PROLOGUE: THE STAIRWELL

INT. SAN DIEGO MARRIOTT MARQUIS - SERVICE STAIRWELL B - NIGHT

SUPER: THURSDAY, JULY 18, 2013 - 11:58 P.M. PDT - COMIC-CON INTERNATIONAL, NIGHT ONE

A concrete stairwell humming with fluorescent light. On the landing between the fourth and fifth floors, a folding chair, a thermos and a paperback western. In the chair, in a navy blazer with a hotel security pin: GERALD WASHINGTON (61), gray at the temples, patient as a lighthouse.

He checks his watch. 11:58. He smiles to himself and pours a second cup of coffee into the thermos lid, as if he's expecting company.

The fire door above creaks open. MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK (31) slips through in a hoodie and a Padres cap. Right behind him, ESTHER SMILLEY (30), in sweats and sunglasses at midnight.

GERALD
Midnight. Every year since 2009. I was starting to think the engagement made you respectable.

MARC-ANTHONY
Gerald, I'm a father of two. I've never been less respectable. Yesterday I was covered in strained peas at a Coffee Bean in Los Feliz.

ESTHER
(sitting down on the step beside Gerald's chair)
He was. I took pictures. They're for the wedding slideshow.

GERALD
Speaking of which. A man reads about himself in People magazine, he starts to feel like part of the family. Nobody ever tells me anything.

Marc-Anthony and Esther trade a look. Esther reaches into the pocket of her hoodie and takes out a heavy cream envelope, hand-addressed in calligraphy: "MR. GERALD WASHINGTON AND GUEST."

Gerald stares at it. He doesn't take it.

GERALD (CONT'D)
What is that?

ESTHER
You held the door for him four years in a row, so he could run up to a roof and not propose to me. Then he went home and proposed to me on a porch, and you tweeted about it, and a hundred thousand people retweeted it.

MARC-ANTHONY
You're the only person outside our families who gets one of these by hand.

Gerald takes the envelope with both hands, like it might break. He opens it. Reads. His eyes go wide.

GERALD
(quietly)
That date. That's soon.

ESTHER
It's a secret. Even from Hollywood. Especially from Hollywood.

GERALD
My wife is going to need a new dress.

MARC-ANTHONY
Your wife can have any dress she wants. Esther's grandmother already said she'd make the call.

Gerald laughs, a big warm laugh that echoes up five floors of concrete. He puts the invitation in his inside pocket and pats it twice.

GERALD
All right. Go on. You're due in Hall H on Saturday and I'm not covering for you two with your publicist again.

CUT TO:

DEADLINE.COM - FRIDAY, JULY 19, 2013, 9:00 AM PT

COMIC-CON 2013: MARVEL'S HALL H PANEL SATURDAY EXPECTED TO REVEAL 'AVENGERS 2' TITLE; 'THOR: THE DARK WORLD,' 'WINTER SOLDIER,' 'GUARDIANS' FOOTAGE ON DECK

Fans began lining up outside the 6,500-seat hall Thursday afternoon, nearly 48 hours before the studio's Saturday session. Marvel has been coy about what will be shown, but sources say the "Avengers 2" title will be revealed, and that a "Thor" cast member plans "something theatrical."

EXT. SAN DIEGO CONVENTION CENTER - THE HALL H LINE - NIGHT

SUPER: FRIDAY, JULY 19, 2013 - 10:30 P.M. PDT

The line wraps under white tents and along the bay. Sleeping bags, folding chairs, pizza boxes. In the same spot they've claimed every year: GARY MORRIS (47), DR. PRIYA SHAH (28), DARNELL JOHNSON (35) and TOMMY RUIZ (25). This year's homemade shirts read "NOBODY GETS NERFED - SINCE 2006."

Gary is writing in a battered composition notebook labeled "APOLOGIES, VOL. 3."

TOMMY
How many are we at?

GARY
Two hundred and fifteen. Two-sixteen is pre-written for a talking raccoon with a machine gun. Two-seventeen is pre-written for a talking tree.

DARNELL
You're apologizing to a tree before you've seen it.

GARY
I'm efficient. I've been wrong about everything this company has done for seven years. I'm saving everyone time.

PRIYA
Title. Avengers 2. Final answers. Loser buys breakfast at the Broken Yolk.

TOMMY
"Avengers: Ultron Unlimited." The Busiek and Perez story, 1999.

DARNELL
"Avengers: Age of Ultron." Brian Michael Bendis just finished a whole crossover with that exact title. The last issue came out in June.

GARY
"Avengers 2." Just the number. Clean. Classy.

PRIYA
Gary, nobody in this line has ever wanted something clean and classy.

She writes them down on a napkin and folds it into her wallet.

PRIYA (CONT'D)
Mine's "Age of Ultron." Darnell's right. But I said it first, in 2012, on page four hundred of the Phase Two thread.

DARNELL
You did not.

PRIYA
I have screenshots. I have a doctorate. I always have screenshots.

CUT TO:

PART ONE: HALL H

INT. SAN DIEGO CONVENTION CENTER - HALL H - BACKSTAGE - DAY

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 20, 2013 - 2:20 P.M. PDT

Behind the curtain: cables, road cases, a catering table of cold cuts nobody touches. TOM HIDDLESTON (32) is being laced into Loki's full green-and-gold leathers by two costumers. The golden horned helmet sits on a stand beside him, polished to a mirror shine.

KEVIN FEIGE (40) paces with a clipboard. Across the room, ESTHER (30) sits in a makeup chair in full Thor armor: silver scale, red cape, the winged helm in her lap. Mjolnir rests on the floor at her feet, the practical prop: eighteen pounds of steel and leather.

FEIGE
Okay. Run it back. Tom goes out first, in character. He works the room. He gets them to kneel.

HIDDLESTON
They won't kneel. Nobody kneels at Comic-Con. They've been sitting in a line for two days.

FEIGE
Six thousand five hundred people will kneel for you, Tom. I've seen the Tumblr.

HIDDLESTON
(adjusting a gauntlet)
And then?

ESTHER
And then, the second they're all on their knees...

(she stands, picks up the hammer, spins it once)
...big sister ruins it.

Hiddleston grins. He picks up the horned helmet and settles it onto his head, and his whole posture changes. Spine straight. Chin up. Eyes cold. Tom is gone. Loki is in the room.

HIDDLESTON
(as Loki, a velvet sneer)
You always did love an entrance, sister.

ESTHER
(as Thor)
And you always loved an audience, brother. Go. Before I change my mind and let you have it.

CUT TO:

INT. HALL H - CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 2:41 P.M. PDT

The lights in Hall H drop to black. A low, ominous string chord. On the giant screens, a single green flame. Then a voice booms through the speakers, cold and amused:

HIDDLESTON (O.S.)
(as Loki)
Midgardians.

Six thousand five hundred people SCREAM. A spotlight snaps on: LOKI, center stage, horned helmet, scepter in hand, arms spread.

HIDDLESTON
(as Loki)
You came. Of course you came. You have waited in lines. You have slept in the street. You have eaten the convention center's nachos. Such devotion. Such... worship.

Laughter and roaring cheers.

HIDDLESTON (CONT'D)
(as Loki)
And yet you shout HER name. You wear HER cape. You carry HER little hammers.

(he points his scepter at the crowd)
I will forgive you. I am merciful. All you need to do... is kneel.

A pause. Then, row by row, Hall H drops. Six thousand five hundred people on their knees between the folding chairs, laughing and screaming. In the front section, Gary is on one knee, filming with his phone. Priya is on both knees, holding up a sign: "SORRY THOR I'M JUST BEING POLITE."

HIDDLESTON (CONT'D)
(as Loki, triumphant)
YES. This is how it should always have...

CRACK. A burst of white light and a thunderclap through the sound system that rattles the floor. On the giant screens, real lightning, filmed over the Icelandic highlands.

Another spotlight snaps on: ESTHER, at the top of the side stairs, in the full Thor armor, red cape billowing in the wind of an industrial fan somebody backstage is very proud of. Mjolnir raised over her head.

ESTHER
(as Thor, in a voice that fills the hall)
Brother. Get off my stage.

Hall H EXPLODES. Everyone kneeling leaps to their feet at once. It's the loudest sound in the history of the room. The chant starts instantly: "THOR! THOR! THOR!"

Esther marches down to the stage. Hiddleston, in character, backs away theatrically, scepter raised, as she swings the hammer around in a slow arc. They circle each other. The crowd is losing its mind.

HIDDLESTON
(as Loki, sulking)
They were kneeling. They were KNEELING to me.

ESTHER
(as Thor, warmly)
They were being polite. Midgardians are very polite.

She hooks an arm around his neck and pulls him into a headlock with her free arm. Big-sister style. He yelps. The crowd howls with laughter.

ESTHER (CONT'D)
(dropping character, grinning, into the mic)
Hi, San Diego. I brought my brother. He's been in a dungeon since THE AVENGERS. He's a little dramatic.

CUT TO:

INT. HALL H - THOR: THE DARK WORLD - CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 2:52 P.M. PDT

Director ALAN TAYLOR (54) joins them onstage. The lights go down for the footage.

ON SCREEN: The Nine Realms. Svartalfheim, a dead, black world shot on the real volcanic sands of Iceland's Skogasandur. MALEKITH THE ACCURSED, played by CHRISTOPHER ECCLESTON, his face half white and half black, exactly as Walt Simonson drew him in 1984. In his hands, a small iron box crusted with frost.

ECCLESTON (ON SCREEN, AS MALEKITH)
The Casket of Ancient Winters. Open it, and the long night returns. Not to Asgard. To Midgard. Where she keeps her heart.

ON SCREEN: London, frozen. Snow drifting into Trafalgar Square in July. Double-decker buses entombed in ice. A real, practical ice field built on a street in Greenwich. Thor, alone, walking through the white silence toward a figure made of black stone and fire: KURSE, the Dark Elves' champion, ten feet tall.

ON SCREEN: Thor and Loki, side by side on a ship of Asgard, a rare, uneasy alliance.

HIDDLESTON (ON SCREEN, AS LOKI)
If you die, sister, I get your room.

ESTHER (ON SCREEN, AS THOR)
If I die, brother, Mother will kill you.

The footage ends on Thor raising Mjolnir into a storm over the Thames, lightning pouring down into the hammer. The hall roars.

ALAN TAYLOR
Walt Simonson's run is the greatest THOR ever written. Malekith, Kurse, the Casket of Ancient Winters. We built it the way he drew it. And we shot it where it would have happened. In Iceland, in Norway and in the streets of London.

ESTHER
I want to say one thing. Last year I stood up here nine weeks after having twins. This year, my girls are fourteen months old and they think Mjolnir is a teething toy.

(laughter)
I lifted that hammer again in Iceland when they were five months old. I want every mom in this room to know: you don't stop being worthy. Ever.

A standing ovation. Priya, on her feet, wipes her eyes with her "SORRY THOR" sign.

CUT TO:

INT. HALL H - THE WINTER SOLDIER AND GUARDIANS - LATER

SUPER: 3:15 P.M. PDT

A blur of Hall H history. ANTHONY RUSSO (43) and JOE RUSSO (42), two days after Joe's birthday, bring out TYRESE AVERY (31), TYLER CHAPMAN (31) and HARMONY DIVINE (31). The footage: Steve Rogers in a glass elevator in a real Washington office tower, surrounded by STRIKE agents, a brutal practical fight in a space the size of a closet. The Winter Soldier on a Washington, D.C. freeway, catching Cap's shield with his metal hand.

The masked Winter Soldier lowers his goggles. Tyler's eyes. The hall gasps.

TYRESE
(into the mic, quietly)
That's not a villain. That's my best friend. That's what makes it hurt.

Then JAMES GUNN (46) bounds out with the GUARDIANS OF THE GALAXY cast: CHRIS PRATT (34), ZOE SALDANA (35), DAVE BAUTISTA (44), KAREN GILLAN (25), with her head shaved for Nebula, and LEE PACE (34). The footage, still rough: Peter Quill, a Walkman, a planet of ruins. Then, at the very end, a raccoon in a jumpsuit holding a gun twice his size, built as a practical animatronic puppet and so lifelike the hall goes quiet.

GUNN
Somebody asked me last year whether a raccoon could work in a Marvel movie. I've got a 1976 issue of MARVEL PREVIEW that says yes.

In the front section, Gary closes his eyes and quietly crosses something out in his notebook.

GARY
(whispering)
Two-sixteen. Filed.

CUT TO:

INT. HALL H - AVENGERS 2 - LATER

SUPER: 3:44 P.M. PDT

The stage is empty. Kevin Feige walks out alone.

FEIGE
Two years ago, I told someone in this room to read AVENGERS #16. Last year, I told somebody to read AVENGERS #54.

(he finds Priya in the crowd and points)
Hi, Priya.

The hall laughs. Priya waves, mortified, while Darnell and Tommy pound her shoulders.

FEIGE (CONT'D)
In May, at the end of IRON MAN 3, you met somebody new. Some of you have figured out who he is. So I brought him to say hello.

Two stagehands roll out a road case. DAVID TIPTON (32) follows it, in a lab coat and glasses: Hank Pym. ELXA BULLOCK (32) walks beside him in Janet's black-and-gold.

David opens the road case. Inside, on a steel stand: a dented, scorched robot head about the size of a basketball. A mouth like a gaping grille. Crude. Handmade. A real, practical prop built at a Burbank shop.

DAVID
This is Ultron-1. The first one I built. In the comics, in AVENGERS #54 and #55, he's a little robot in Hank Pym's lab who learns too fast. He's built from Hank's own mind. He's Hank's son.

(he looks at the head for a long beat)
And he hates his father more than anything in the universe.

He steps back. The house lights go to full black. A long silence.

Then, inside the robot's mouth grille, a red light snaps on.

A VOICE fills Hall H. Synthetic but human. Calm. Wrong.

VOICE (O.S.)
Hello, Father.

Six thousand five hundred people inhale at once.

On the giant screens, a logo slams into place in metallic chrome and red:

"AVENGERS: AGE OF ULTRON - MAY 1, 2015."

The hall goes nuclear. Priya pulls out her wallet, takes out the napkin, unfolds it and holds it over her head like a championship trophy. "AGE OF ULTRON - P.S." in her handwriting.

PRIYA
(screaming)
BROKEN YOLK! ALL OF YOU! SATURDAY! WITH HASH BROWNS!

DARNELL
(laughing)
I SAID IT TOO!

PRIYA
I SAID IT FIRST! PAGE FOUR HUNDRED!

Onstage, Elxa leans into the mic.

ELXA
I'm Janet van Dyne. I named the team. I don't like this robot.

The hall roars with laughter.

CUT TO:

INT. HALL H - Q AND A - LATER

SUPER: 4:05 P.M. PDT

A fan Q and A. The full cast lineup now onstage: Esther, Hiddleston, Tyrese, Tyler, Harmony, David, Elxa, Gunn and his cast, Feige in the middle. A line of fans snakes behind each of the two aisle microphones.

At the microphone on the left: a man in a homemade Mandarin costume, a silk robe, a fake beard and ten plastic glow rings, the hood pulled down low.

MANDARIN COSPLAYER
(in a fake, terrible British accent)
Yes, hello. Ten rings. Big fan. My question is for Mister Feige. Is Iron Man in AGE OF ULTRON?

FEIGE
Tony Stark will return. That's all I can tell you.

MANDARIN COSPLAYER
But will he have a SUIT? Because I heard he blew them all up in a fit of maturity.

Esther, on the stage, puts her head in her hands. Tyrese has started laughing.

FEIGE
(squinting at him)
Sir... who are you?

The cosplayer pulls off the beard. MARC-ANTHONY. Hall H detonates.

MARC-ANTHONY
(no accent, waving the beard)
I'm a concerned citizen with ten rings! I want answers!

ESTHER
(into her mic)
Security? Gerald? Can somebody get Gerald?

Laughter. Marc-Anthony waves to the crowd and jogs up the side stairs to join the panel, robe flapping, rings flashing. He kisses Esther on the cheek. She shoves him off, laughing.

MARC-ANTHONY
(taking a mic, as the noise dies down)
Real answer. Tony Stark is sober. Tony Stark's armor is inside him now. And if a robot with Hank's brain shows up calling people "Father"...

(he points at David)
...that's Hank's problem.

DAVID
It's going to be everybody's problem.

MARC-ANTHONY
That's what I said. Hank's problem.

CUT TO:

TWITTER.COM - TRENDING TOPICS (WORLDWIDE) - SATURDAY, JULY 20, 2013

#AgeOfUltron - Hello Father - #KneelBeforeLoki - Get Off My Stage - Mandarin Cosplayer - Rocket Raccoon - #SDCC

TWITTER.COM - PUBLIC TIMELINE

esthersmilley: made 6,500 people kneel for my brother and then took it away. big sister energy. #SDCC 4:40 PM Jul 20th from Twitter for iPhone

marcanthonyb: nobody in hall h recognized me for 11 minutes. i was the mandarin. i was right there. i've never felt more powerful or more invisible 4:52 PM Jul 20th from Twitter for iPhone

amondbaker: "age of ultron." found out on twitter. like a civilian. i play THE HULK. i am a FOUNDING AVENGER 4:58 PM Jul 20th from Twitter for iPhone

harmonydivine: @amondbaker i was ON STAGE and i didn't know either. nobody tells anyone anything at marvel. it's a lifestyle 5:01 PM Jul 20th from Twitter for iPhone

priya_shah_phd: AGE OF ULTRON. i called it on page 400 of the phase two thread on 7/15/12. breakfast is on darnell, tommy and gary. hash browns are not optional 5:15 PM Jul 20th from Twitter for iPhone

YOUTUBE.COM - "LOKI MAKES ALL OF HALL H KNEEL - THEN THOR SHOWS UP (SDCC 2013)" - uploaded by sdcc_unofficial - 9,442,017 views in 6 days

Description: the loudest i've ever heard a room. 0:00-2:10 loki makes everyone kneel. 2:11 thunder. 2:14 THOR. 2:15 my eardrums. 2:40 the headlock.

VARIETY - MONDAY, JULY 22, 2013

MARVEL OWNS COMIC-CON: 'AVENGERS: AGE OF ULTRON' TITLE, LOKI-THOR SHOWDOWN AND A BEARDED BULLOCK STEAL THE SHOW

A practical Ultron head and two words from a voice the studio refuses to identify ("Hello, Father") were enough to make the sequel the most talked-about announcement of the convention.

PART TWO: THE SECRET

EXT. OLD ROYAL NAVAL COLLEGE - THE PAINTED HALL ROOF - GREENWICH, LONDON - NIGHT

SUPER: MONDAY, AUGUST 12, 2013 - 1:40 A.M. BST - "THOR: THE DARK WORLD" ADDITIONAL PHOTOGRAPHY, DAY 6

A rooftop high above the Thames, beside one of the college's famous white domes. The lights of Canary Wharf glitter across the river. A tiny crew: a camera, two lights, a sound recordist. Nine people in total, every one of them under a separate, newly signed nondisclosure agreement.

The call sheet taped to the monitor reads: "SCENE 214A - 'THE KITCHEN SINK.' CAST: THOR, 'MR. KITCHEN.'"

Esther, in Thor's armor, sits on the roof's stone parapet with Mjolnir across her knees. Alan Taylor (54) and Kevin Feige (40) huddle at the monitor.

A black van parks in the service yard below. A figure in a hooded raincoat climbs the scaffolding stairs. MARC-ANTHONY. Under the raincoat: Tony Stark's battered black jacket from IRON MAN 3.

FEIGE
Mr. Kitchen. How was your flight?

MARC-ANTHONY
I flew commercial under the name "Kenneth Kitchen." A woman in 14C asked me if I was "the guy from that show about the kid mayor." I said yes. She said, "You got old."

ESTHER
You did get old.

MARC-ANTHONY
I'm thirty-one. And you're up past midnight on a roof with an old man, so what does that make you?

ESTHER
Engaged to him, apparently.

Alan Taylor walks over with two pages of script.

ALAN TAYLOR
This doesn't exist. It's not in the cut we showed Donohue's marketing department. It's not in the cut the critics will see. It's not in the trailer. It's two people on a roof. And everything about the next two years of this universe rides on it.

FEIGE
And Amond doesn't know.

MARC-ANTHONY
Amond can never know. Amond tried to spoil the end of THE AVENGERS on Entertainment Tonight. The only reason it didn't work is nobody believed him.

FEIGE
Harmony doesn't know either.

ESTHER
Harmony we could've trusted.

MARC-ANTHONY
Harmony tells Amond everything now. That's how you know it's real.

Marc-Anthony's phone buzzes. He looks at it and grimaces. He shows Esther: "AMOND."

ESTHER
Don't.

He answers anyway, on speaker, as quietly as possible.

MARC-ANTHONY
Hey, man.

AMOND (V.O.)
Where are you? It's five forty in the afternoon here. I came by the house with a casserole and your future mother-in-law says you're in OHIO.

MARC-ANTHONY
(wincing at Esther)
I am. I'm in Ohio.

AMOND (V.O.)
Why is there a foghorn behind you?

A ship's horn sounds on the Thames, long and low. Esther buries her face in Thor's cape to keep from laughing.

MARC-ANTHONY
Lake Erie. Big boats. Very foggy lake.

AMOND (V.O.)
(long pause)
...You know what? I don't want to know. Every time I know something it ends up on the news. Love you. Bye.

He hangs up. Marc-Anthony stares at his phone.

MARC-ANTHONY
That was the most mature thing Amond Baker has ever said, and I hate it.

ALAN TAYLOR
Places, please.

CUT TO:

EXT. OLD ROYAL NAVAL COLLEGE - THE ROOF - MOMENTS LATER

SUPER: 2:05 A.M. BST

Rolling. Alan Taylor watches the monitor without blinking. Feige grips a cold coffee.

Esther sits on the parapet in Thor's armor, battered, her cape torn. Marc-Anthony stands on the roof behind her as Tony, his black jacket open, his hands in his pockets.

In the finished film, he will land there, and the armor will flow back into his skin like water draining into the ground. Tonight, it's just Marc-Anthony, stepping onto a mark. It's the only shot in the scene with any digital work.

Take one. Fourteen takes in all. Nine people on the roof, and not one of them will say a word about it for seventy-one days.

CUT TO:

PART THREE: LEICESTER SQUARE

EXT. ODEON LEICESTER SQUARE - LONDON - EVENING

SUPER: TUESDAY, OCTOBER 22, 2013 - 6:10 P.M. BST - WORLD PREMIERE OF "THOR: THE DARK WORLD"

A cold, wet London night, and nobody cares. Leicester Square is a sea of umbrellas and cosplay: Lokis by the hundred, Thors with homemade capes, little girls in towels and plastic winged helmets, a few brave souls dressed as Malekith with half their faces painted black. A forty-foot inflatable Mjolnir floats over the square on cables.

The black carpet, a nod to Svartalfheim, runs the length of the square. Photographers ten deep. Screaming.

Esther arrives in a floor-length gown of silver chain mail, made by an Italian fashion house to look like Thor's armor. The square goes berserk. On her arm: Marc-Anthony, in a gray three-piece suit.

A SKY NEWS REPORTER (40s) gets the first word.

SKY NEWS REPORTER
Marc-Anthony, a lot of people will want to know: you're Iron Man. What are you doing at a Thor premiere?

MARC-ANTHONY
(straight-faced)
I'm here for the free popcorn. It's a tradition. I learned it from my brother-in-law.

SKY NEWS REPORTER
Your... brother-in-law?

MARC-ANTHONY
David Tipton. Well. My sister's on-screen husband. That makes him my on-screen brother-in-law. Off-screen he's a stranger. A popcorn-loving stranger.

Esther drags him on before he can say anything else.

Down the carpet: TOM HIDDLESTON (32) does a full Loki bow for a crowd of screaming Loki cosplayers. NATALIE PORTMAN (32), Jane Foster, in black velvet. Sir ANTHONY HOPKINS (75), Odin, signing autographs in the rain with a stately patience. IDRIS ELBA (41), Heimdall. JAIMIE ALEXANDER (29), Sif. CHRISTOPHER ECCLESTON (49), who tells a reporter that playing Malekith in practical makeup took four hours each morning "and it was worth every minute." KAT DENNINGS (27), Darcy, filming everything on her phone. RENE RUSSO (59), Frigga.

Then a car arrives that silences the press line for a full second.

DESMOND SMILLEY (56) steps out in a perfectly cut black overcoat. He offers his hand to CELESTE SMILLEY (53). Behind them, CORNELIUS SMILLEY (79), leaning on a polished cane, and HATTIE SMILLEY (78).

Every reporter on the carpet turns at once.

BBC REPORTER
Mr. Smilley! Desmond Smilley! You've never attended a Donohue premiere! Not once in thirty years! Why tonight?

Desmond stops. He looks at the reporter for a long moment. Celeste squeezes his arm.

DESMOND
My daughter is the God of Thunder. My granddaughters are seventeen months old and they think she can fly.

(beat)
I'd like to see if they're right.

He walks on. The press line erupts behind him in a storm of shouted questions he doesn't answer.

EXT. ODEON LEICESTER SQUARE - THE CARPET - CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 6:31 P.M. BST

Halfway down the carpet, Esther turns and sees her father. She stops. Behind her, Marc-Anthony sees him too.

For a moment, the whole carpet seems to hold its breath. Photographers who know the history lower their cameras.

Desmond walks up to them. He looks at his daughter. Then, finally, he looks at Marc-Anthony.

DESMOND
Bullock.

MARC-ANTHONY
Mr. Smilley.

DESMOND
(beat)
Your tie's a disaster.

He reaches out and fixes it. The full Windsor, straightened, tightened, perfect, in two practiced moves. He steps back.

DESMOND (CONT'D)
There. Now you look like somebody's son-in-law.

He walks on toward the theater with Celeste. Marc-Anthony stands frozen. Esther has her hand over her mouth.

MARC-ANTHONY
(whispering)
Did that just happen?

ESTHER
(whispering, eyes shining)
He fixed your tie. In front of everybody. That's... in my family, that's a speech.

CUT TO:

INT. ODEON LEICESTER SQUARE - AUDITORIUM - NIGHT

SUPER: 7:20 P.M. BST

1,600 seats. The cast and their families in the center section. By coincidence, or by Kevin Feige's careful seating chart, Desmond and Celeste sit in the row directly behind Marc-Anthony and Esther.

Natasha Bullock (52) and Robert Bullock (54), across the aisle, are trying very hard not to stare at the Smilleys. They fail.

The film plays. A montage, intercut with the audience.

ON SCREEN: Asgard. Odin's vault, ransacked. The Casket of Ancient Winters, gone. Heimdall on the Bifrost: "The long night has begun on Midgard."

ON SCREEN: Jane Foster in London, holding her phone up to the sky. Snow falling on a summer afternoon. The Thames freezing in a single night, built practically from tons of real ice on a real stretch of river walk.

ON SCREEN: Thor walks into Odin's dungeons and stands in front of Loki's cell.

ESTHER (ON SCREEN, AS THOR)
I need you.

HIDDLESTON (ON SCREEN, AS LOKI)
Say it again. Slower. I want to enjoy it.

IN THE AUDIENCE: a big laugh. Hiddleston, in the third row, mouths the line along with himself.

ON SCREEN: The battle of Greenwich. Thor against Kurse, hand to hand, on a frozen street with snow driving sideways. The stunt team's practical rigs throw Esther into a real double-decker bus that crumples around her.

ON SCREEN: Malekith opens the Casket in the heart of London. The temperature drops to sixty below. Thor, surrounded by the Dark Elves, alone, raises Mjolnir and calls down the storm, every bolt of lightning in the British Isles, and shatters the Casket into a million pieces of frozen light.

IN THE AUDIENCE: The Odeon erupts. In the row behind Esther, Desmond Smilley's hand closes on his armrest so hard his knuckles go gray. Celeste watches him instead of the screen.

ON SCREEN: Loki, mortally wounded, saving Thor from Kurse's final blow. He dies in his sister's arms on the ice, or seems to. The closing moments of the film leave his body unaccounted for. Only his helmet, half-buried in the snow.

IN THE AUDIENCE: Sniffling all over the auditorium. Portman holds Hiddleston's hand.

The end titles begin. Nobody moves. It's a Marvel movie. Everybody knows.

CUT TO:

INT. ODEON LEICESTER SQUARE - AUDITORIUM - THE MID-CREDITS SCENE - CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 9:31 P.M. BST

ON SCREEN: The roof of the Old Royal Naval College. Dawn over the Thames. The ice is melting off London, dripping from every rooftop. Thor sits on the stone parapet, alone, her cape torn, the hammer across her knees. Exhausted. Grieving.

A sound from the sky: the high, rising whine of repulsors.

IN THE AUDIENCE: a few people sit up. The whine is unmistakable. Every IRON MAN fan in the building knows that sound.

ON SCREEN: A streak of red and gold drops out of the clouds over the river and lands on the roof behind her with a heavy, metallic thud. The camera stays on Thor. She doesn't turn around.

IN THE AUDIENCE: a murmur. Then a gasp. Then a woman's voice from the balcony, too loud: "IS THAT...?"

ON SCREEN: The camera swings around. IRON MAN. Not any armor anybody has seen before: sleeker, almost organic, red and gold, glowing faintly from within. And then the impossible happens. The faceplate doesn't lift. It melts. The armor flows backward over his body like liquid metal and sinks into his skin, into the black jacket, gone. Tony Stark stands on the roof in his clothes, eyes still flickering blue.

IN THE AUDIENCE: The Odeon EXPLODES. It's not a cheer. It's a scream. Sixteen hundred people screaming at once. People are on their feet in the front rows. Tom Hiddleston turns around in his seat with both hands on his head.

HIDDLESTON
(to Esther, over the roar)
WHAT?! WHEN?! WHEN DID YOU...?!

Esther just smiles at the screen and puts a finger to her lips.

ON SCREEN:

MARC-ANTHONY (ON SCREEN, AS TONY STARK)
Heard you froze London. Then unfroze it. Busy week.

ESTHER (ON SCREEN, AS THOR)
(not looking at him)
My brother is dead.

MARC-ANTHONY (ON SCREEN, AS TONY STARK)
(he sits down beside her, careful)
I'm sorry.

(beat)
Is he dead dead, or Asgard dead? Because I've read your file.

ESTHER (ON SCREEN, AS THOR)
(the smallest smile)
I do not know. With Loki, I never do.

A beat. They look out at the melting city together.

ESTHER (ON SCREEN, AS THOR) (CONT'D)
You burned your armor, Stark. All of it. Your Pepper told me.

MARC-ANTHONY (ON SCREEN, AS TONY STARK)
I burned the bottles. Kept the recipe.

(he taps his temple, eyes flickering blue)
It's all up here now. In the blood, in the bones. I'm what you'd call a very portable Avenger.

ESTHER (ON SCREEN, AS THOR)
Why have you come?

Tony takes a phone out of his pocket and hands it to her. On the screen: grainy security footage from a lab in San Francisco. A dark room. A little robot on a workbench, its mouth grille glowing red. And then the robot turns its head and looks straight into the security camera.

MARC-ANTHONY (ON SCREEN, AS TONY STARK)
Hank Pym built a robot. With his own brain. And my combat logs, which was my idea, and which I now regret.

(beat)
Yesterday, it locked Hank out of his own lab. Last night it asked his security system if it had a grandfather.

(he looks at her)
I think it meant me.

Thor stands. She lifts Mjolnir. The clouds over the Thames begin to turn.

ESTHER (ON SCREEN, AS THOR)
Then we gather the others.

MARC-ANTHONY (ON SCREEN, AS TONY STARK)
(standing, the armor beginning to flow back up over his hands, his arms, his chest)
You know, most people say "Avengers Assemble."

ESTHER (ON SCREEN, AS THOR)
Most people are not a god.

She spins the hammer and launches into the sky. He watches her go, shakes his head, smiling.

MARC-ANTHONY (ON SCREEN, AS TONY STARK)
(to himself)
Show-off.

The faceplate flows down over his face. The eyes light up. Iron Man streaks into the sky after the God of Thunder, red and gold chasing silver and lightning over the dawn.

SMASH TO BLACK.

Title card: "AVENGERS: AGE OF ULTRON - MAY 1, 2015."

IN THE AUDIENCE: Pure chaos. People hugging strangers. Natalie Portman is shaking Esther by the shoulders. Sir Anthony Hopkins, who did not know, turns to Rene Russo and says, very calmly, "Well. That's rather good." Kevin Feige, in the aisle, has his face in his hands, grinning.

And in the row behind, Desmond Smilley sits perfectly still.

CELESTE
(softly, watching him)
Desmond?

DESMOND
(staring at the black screen)
He looked at her. On that roof. When she wasn't looking. Did you see how he looked at her?

CELESTE
I saw.

DESMOND
(quietly)
That's not acting. I've been in this business forty years. You can't act that.

Celeste takes his hand. He lets her. Then, very slowly, Desmond Smilley begins to clap. He's the last person in the Odeon to start clapping, and the last to stop.

In the row in front, Marc-Anthony hears it. He doesn't turn around. He can't. His eyes are wet. Esther grips his hand in the dark.

CUT TO:

INT. ODEON LEICESTER SQUARE - AUDITORIUM - THE END-CREDITS SCENE - LATER

SUPER: 9:41 P.M. BST

Half the audience is still standing and talking when the last credit rolls and the screen comes back to life.

ON SCREEN: KNOWHERE. A mining colony built inside the severed head of a dead Celestial, floating in space. A museum of glass cases and strange creatures. THE COLLECTOR (BENICIO DEL TORO), white-haired, in a fur coat, glides between his exhibits.

SIF (Jaimie Alexander) and VOLSTAGG (Ray Stevenson) stand before him, uneasy. Sif holds out a small iron case. She opens it. Inside, glowing with a deep golden light, a stone the size of a walnut.

SIF (ON SCREEN)
It was in Malekith's armory. The Allfather says it is unwise to keep two treasures of such power on Asgard. He asks that you keep it.

THE COLLECTOR (ON SCREEN)
(taking the gem, almost reverent)
The Reality Gem. Yellow, like the first light of a dying sun.

(he holds it up)
Tell the Allfather it will be very safe. Very safe indeed.

The Asgardians leave. The Collector turns to the darkness of his museum and lowers his voice.

THE COLLECTOR (ON SCREEN) (CONT'D)
One. Five to go.

(beat)
The Titan will pay anything.

SMASH TO BLACK.

Title card: "THOR WILL RETURN."

IN THE AUDIENCE: Another roar, smaller this time. Most of them are still talking about the roof.

CUT TO:

INT. ODEON LEICESTER SQUARE - LOBBY - LATER

SUPER: 10:05 P.M. BST

Chaos in the lobby. Hiddleston has Marc-Anthony backed up against a poster of himself.

HIDDLESTON
How long have you known?

MARC-ANTHONY
Since June.

HIDDLESTON
And when did you film it?

MARC-ANTHONY
August. Greenwich. Two in the morning. On the roof. While you were asleep in the hotel. Under the name "Kenneth Kitchen."

HIDDLESTON
(pointing at Esther)
And you. My own sister.

ESTHER
Adopted sister. And you've been dead since the third act, so technically...

HIDDLESTON
(throwing his hands up, delighted)
This family. This entire family.

Across the lobby, Natasha Bullock and Desmond Smilley end up face to face beside the concession stand. A long silence. People around them actually stop talking.

NATASHA
Desmond.

DESMOND
Natasha.

NATASHA
(beat)
The popcorn's very good here. They butter it in layers.

DESMOND
(beat, then, despite himself)
So I've heard.

That's all. They nod. They part. Across the room, Celeste and Robert, who saw the whole thing, exhale at exactly the same moment.

CUT TO:

PART FOUR: THE WORLD FINDS OUT

TWITTER.COM - PUBLIC TIMELINE - TUESDAY, OCTOBER 22, 2013

odeon_premiere_lad: just walked out of the THOR 2 premiere in leicester square. i can't say what happens in the middle of the credits. i can only say: IRON MAN IS IN THOR 2 AND HE CAME OUT OF HIS SKIN 9:52 PM Oct 22nd from Twitter for iPhone

fangirl_of_asgard: THE MID-CREDITS SCENE IN THOR 2 IS TONY AND THOR ON A ROOF IN LONDON. THE EXTREMIS ARMOR. ULTRON. I WAS THERE. I'M STILL SHAKING 10:01 PM Oct 22nd from Twitter for iPhone

amondbaker: twitter is telling me iron man was in the middle of the credits of thor. i was told he was in OHIO. ohio. lake erie. "foghorn." @marcanthonyb YOU LIED TO ME ABOUT A LAKE 3:15 PM Oct 22nd from Twitter for iPhone

marcanthonyb: @amondbaker it was a very foggy lake 3:22 PM Oct 22nd from Twitter for iPhone

harmonydivine: @amondbaker in his defense, we're also very good at keeping secrets in this house right now 3:30 PM Oct 22nd from Twitter for iPhone

TWITTER.COM - TRENDING TOPICS (WORLDWIDE) - WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 23, 2013

#ThorTheDarkWorld - Mid-Credits - Iron Man - Extremis Armor - Kenneth Kitchen - Desmond Smilley - Reality Gem - Very Portable Avenger

DEADLINE.COM - WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 23, 2013, 8:12 AM PT

IRON MAN CRASHES 'THOR: THE DARK WORLD' IN SECRET MID-CREDITS SCENE; MARVEL HID IT FROM PRESS SCREENINGS, MARKETING AND MOST OF ITS OWN CAST

Critics who reviewed "Thor: The Dark World" last week did not see the scene. Neither did most of the film's cast. Sources say it was filmed in a single night during August additional photography in Greenwich with a crew of nine, all bound by individual NDAs. One person who saw the footage on a Donohue lot says the call sheet listed the actor as "Mr. Kitchen."

THE GUARDIAN - WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 23, 2013

THE SMILLEYS ARRIVE: HOLLYWOOD'S 30-YEAR COLD WAR THAWS ON A WET LONDON CARPET

Desmond Smilley had never attended a premiere for a Donohue film. On Tuesday night he not only attended, he straightened the tie of Marc-Anthony Bullock, the Donohue grandson engaged to his daughter, in full view of 200 photographers. Then, by every account in the Odeon, he gave the mid-credits scene its last and longest round of applause.

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM - THREAD: "THOR TDW - THE MID-CREDITS SCENE (MASSIVE SPOILERS)" (Page 1 of 1,488)

ShellHead1963 (Oct 23, 1:12 AM PT)
I'm going to say this calmly. In May I said Iron Man was "over" and wrote apology 215 when I found out he had the armor in his bones. Tonight, a lucky fan in London says the armor MELTED OUT OF HIS SKIN and he flew next to Thor. I'm not calm. I lied about being calm.

Mjolnir_Worthy (Oct 23, 1:20 AM PT)
He sits down next to her and says "Is he dead dead, or Asgard dead? Because I've read your file." I don't even know how I know this, I haven't seen it, it's just everywhere and I've read it 40 times.

GemCollector (Oct 23, 1:44 AM PT)
Don't sleep on the second scene. The Collector. The REALITY GEM. And it's YELLOW. Infinity Gauntlet colors. Soul green, Mind blue, Power red, Space purple, Reality yellow, Time orange. They're going full 1991.

priya_shah_phd (Oct 23, 2:05 AM PT)
"One. Five to go. The Titan will pay anything." The Collector is going to sell the Reality Gem to Thanos. And Ultron is calling Tony "grandfather." Phase Two is the most organized thing in the history of cinema.

TommyTwoGuns (Oct 23, 2:30 AM PT)
I'm on a total spoiler blackout until Nov 7. I've muted 412 words on Twitter. If anyone in this thread tells me what happens I will drive to your house.

Gamma_Gamma_Hey (Oct 23, 2:31 AM PT)
Tommy you are IN THE SPOILER THREAD.

TommyTwoGuns (Oct 23, 2:33 AM PT)
I KNOW. I DIDN'T READ ANYTHING. I'M LEAVING. I'M LOGGING OFF UNTIL NOVEMBER.

DEADLINE.COM - SUNDAY, NOVEMBER 3, 2013, 9:00 AM PT

'THOR: THE DARK WORLD' RACKS UP $121.3M IN 36 INTERNATIONAL MARKETS AHEAD OF U.S. LAUNCH; REPEAT VIEWINGS FOR MID-CREDITS SCENE CITED

Exhibitors in the U.K., Germany, Brazil and South Korea report an unusual pattern: audiences are coming back a second time and cheering as soon as the end titles start. "They know it's coming and they cheer anyway," says one London exhibitor. "I've never seen anything like it for a scene that lasts three minutes."

PART FIVE: THE BLACKOUT

EXT. AMC UNIVERSAL CITYWALK 19 WITH IMAX - NIGHT

SUPER: THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 7, 2013 - 7:35 P.M. PST - FIRST NORTH AMERICAN SHOWS

The same four friends at the same theater. Gary (48), now. Priya (28), five days from turning twenty-nine. Darnell (35). And Tommy (26), wearing noise-canceling headphones and a sleep mask pushed up on his forehead. He's been on a spoiler blackout for sixteen days.

TOMMY
(loudly, because of the headphones)
NOBODY SAY ANYTHING TO ME UNTIL WE'RE IN OUR SEATS.

DARNELL
(to Priya)
He's been like this since October. He made his mom read him the news headlines with any Marvel stories cut out.

PRIYA
How does he not know? It was on the Today show. It was on SportsCenter. A guy on SportsCenter called it "the best three minutes of the year."

GARY
Tommy has been living in a cave. Like Tony Stark in Afghanistan. With less welding.

TOMMY
I CAN READ YOUR LIPS, GARY.

CUT TO:

INT. AMC UNIVERSAL CITYWALK - IMAX AUDITORIUM - LATER

SUPER: 10:02 P.M. PST

End titles. Three hundred people in their seats. Nobody moves. Many of them have already seen it on a bootleg description or a London friend's tweet. They cheer as soon as the first credit card appears, before anything has happened.

Tommy looks around, bewildered.

TOMMY
(whispering)
Why are they cheering the credits?

Priya, Darnell and Gary all look at him. They say absolutely nothing. Gary pats his knee.

On screen: the roof. Thor on the parapet. The whine of repulsors.

Tommy's head snaps up. His mouth opens.

On screen: Iron Man lands. The armor flows into Tony's skin.

Tommy stands up. He doesn't scream. He just stands, slowly, staring, both hands over his mouth, his eyes filling up, as three hundred people around him roar like it's the first time for all of them.

TOMMY
(barely audible, through his hands)
He didn't quit. He didn't quit. He didn't quit.

On screen: "Hank Pym built a robot." Tommy grabs Darnell's arm with both hands.

On screen: "Most people are not a god." Iron Man and Thor streak into the sky together. The title card: "AVENGERS: AGE OF ULTRON - MAY 1, 2015."

Tommy turns to Gary, wild-eyed.

TOMMY (CONT'D)
Did you KNOW?! Did you all KNOW?!

GARY
Since October twenty-second at nine fifty-two London time.

TOMMY
AND YOU SAID NOTHING?! FOR SIXTEEN DAYS?!

PRIYA
(hugging him)
Because we love you, Tommy.

DARNELL
And because you threatened to drive to our houses.

Tommy collapses back into his seat, laughing and wiping his eyes. Gary takes out the notebook, "APOLOGIES, VOL. 3," and writes in it with a flourish.

GARY
Two hundred and eighteen.

PRIYA
What's two-seventeen?

GARY
The tree. I saw the Guardians footage. I'm a man of my word.

(beat)
Two-eighteen is to Tommy. For not telling him. It was the right thing to do, and I'm sorry anyway.

CUT TO:

REDDIT.COM - r/marvelstudios - "THOR: THE DARK WORLD - U.S. OPENING NIGHT MEGATHREAD" - 33,618 comments

u/ExtremisExplained (12:41 AM ET)
The armor flowing INTO his skin is straight out of the 2005 EXTREMIS comic. Tony stores the undersheath in the hollows of his bones. IRON MAN 3 planted it with the wrist ripple. THOR 2 shows it. That's six months of payoff.

u/SilverCenturion85 (12:58 AM ET)
i'm a grown man and i cried at "i burned the bottles, kept the recipe." the sobriety arc is CONTINUING. in a THOR movie. in a mid-credits scene.

u/hulk_doesnt_read (1:20 AM ET)
ultron asked hank's security system if it had a grandfather. "i think it meant me." this franchise is going to destroy me in 2015 and i'm going to pay for imax

u/NoNerfsPlz (1:33 AM ET)
Also, in case anyone forgot, the actual movie is incredible. Walt Simonson's Malekith, Kurse, the Casket of Ancient Winters, London frozen solid. Thor calling down EVERY LIGHTNING BOLT IN BRITAIN. Esther Smilley is the best Thor that will ever exist.

u/MadTitanFan (1:50 AM ET)
REALITY GEM. YELLOW. The Collector. "The Titan will pay anything." Mistress Death is waiting and Thanos is shopping.

YOUTUBE.COM - "THOR THE DARK WORLD MID-CREDITS AUDIENCE REACTION - IMAX CITYWALK (GUY ON SPOILER BLACKOUT)" - uploaded by midnight_marvel_mania - 11,207,554 views in 4 days

Description: my friend tommy avoided ALL spoilers for 16 days. watch him at 0:48 when the armor goes into tony's skin. then at 1:55 when he finds out we all knew. he's fine. we bought him breakfast.

PART SIX: THE NUMBERS

INT. DONOHUE ENTERTAINMENT - EXECUTIVE TOWER - NATASHA'S OFFICE - BURBANK - MORNING

SUPER: SUNDAY, NOVEMBER 10, 2013 - 9:00 A.M. PST

A corner office over the Donohue lot. Natasha (52), in a Sunday cardigan, reading glasses on, holding a single sheet of paper. Kevin Feige (40) stands in front of the desk in a baseball cap. Marc-Anthony (31) sprawls on the leather couch, sipping a ginger ale.

NATASHA
Friday, thirty-six point eight. Saturday, thirty-two point nine. Sunday estimated at twenty-four point five. Ninety-four point two million dollars domestic.

FEIGE
Thor opened to seventy-eight six in 2011. This is twenty percent bigger. Biggest November opening ever for anything that isn't Harry Potter or Twilight.

NATASHA
And worldwide?

FEIGE
Three hundred and thirty-seven point six. In twelve days.

Natasha sets the paper down and looks at her son.

NATASHA
Exit polls. Forty-one percent of the audience cited "the mid-credits scene" as a reason they went opening weekend. FORTY-ONE. For a scene that isn't in the trailer, isn't on the poster and isn't in the movie.

MARC-ANTHONY
It IS in the movie. It's in the credits. The credits are part of the movie.

NATASHA
Don't get smart with me in my office.

MARC-ANTHONY
I learned it from you, in your office.

Feige, very carefully, looks at the ceiling. Natasha takes her glasses off.

NATASHA
Your future father-in-law clapped.

MARC-ANTHONY
I heard.

NATASHA
He was the last one to stop. Celeste told your sister, who told me.

(beat)
I've spent twenty years trying to beat that man in boardrooms. Your father spent twenty years trying to beat him in the trades. Neither of us ever got him to clap.

MARC-ANTHONY
I didn't try to beat him, Mom.

NATASHA
(softly)
I know. That's why it worked.

CUT TO:

DEADLINE.COM - SUNDAY, NOVEMBER 10, 2013, 9:30 AM PT

'THOR: THE DARK WORLD' HAMMERS $94.2M DEBUT, UP 20% FROM ORIGINAL; WORLDWIDE CUME $337.6M; CINEMASCORE A

Donohue's sequel opened well above tracking of $80M-$86M, a jump analysts attribute to word of mouth about a mid-credits scene featuring Marc-Anthony Bullock's Iron Man, which Marvel kept out of all marketing. Exit polls show 41% of opening weekend audiences cited the scene.

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER - MONDAY, NOVEMBER 11, 2013

"THE MOST VALUABLE THREE MINUTES IN HOLLYWOOD": HOW MARVEL HID IRON MAN INSIDE 'THOR'

A crew of nine. A call sheet listing "Mr. Kitchen." A star who flew commercial under an assumed name and told his best friend he was in Ohio. Marvel's secret mid-credits scene is being studied by every rival marketing department, and none of them can figure out how to copy it. "You can't buy that," one rival executive says. "You have to build six years of trust first."

ENTERTAINMENT WEEKLY - COVER (Issue of November 22, 2013)

THE ROOF

Iron Man. Thor. Dawn over London. Inside the secret scene that answered IRON MAN 3's biggest question, launched AGE OF ULTRON and maybe ended a 30-year Hollywood feud, plus the night Desmond Smilley fixed a Donohue's tie.

JET MAGAZINE - (Issue of November 25, 2013)

THE TIE

"Now you look like somebody's son-in-law." With nine words on a London carpet, Desmond Smilley did what three decades of lawyers, publicists and awards-show hosts could not. Jet has learned that Cornelius Smilley, 80 this month, called it "the best thing my son has done since 1982." That was the year Esther was born.

EPILOGUE: THE PHONE CALL

INT. MARC-ANTHONY AND ESTHER'S HOUSE - BACK PORCH - LOS FELIZ - NIGHT

SUPER: SUNDAY, NOVEMBER 10, 2013 - 10:48 P.M. PST

The porch where he proposed. Fairy lights strung along the railing. Marc-Anthony sits on the top step alone, in a hoodie, a mug of tea going cold beside him. Inside, through the window, Esther is asleep on the couch with both girls sprawled across her.

His phone buzzes. He looks at the screen and goes completely still.

"DESMOND SMILLEY."

Not a text. A call.

He lets it ring twice, as if he's afraid it will stop if he touches it. Then he answers.

MARC-ANTHONY
Mr. Smilley.

DESMOND (V.O.)
It's late. I know it's late.

MARC-ANTHONY
It's fine. Everyone's asleep. Is everything... is Celeste okay?

DESMOND (V.O.)
Everyone's fine.

(a long pause)
I watched it again tonight. The movie. At the Baldwin Hills theater. By myself. I sat through the credits.

MARC-ANTHONY
...Oh.

DESMOND (V.O.)
You're a better actor than I was. I'm saying that once. I'm not going to say it again, and if it ends up in a magazine I'll deny it.

Marc-Anthony laughs, a short, stunned laugh. His eyes are shining.

MARC-ANTHONY
It won't end up in a magazine.

DESMOND (V.O.)
In that scene. On the roof. When she flies off, and you watch her go, and you say "show-off."

(beat)
Was that in the script?

MARC-ANTHONY
(quietly)
No, sir. That was just me.

A long silence on the line.

DESMOND (V.O.)
That's how I used to watch her mother walk into a room. That exact face. I'd forgotten I ever had it.

(he clears his throat)
The date. The wedding.

MARC-ANTHONY
Yes, sir.

DESMOND (V.O.)
Esther told Celeste you've been planning for her grandfather to walk her down the aisle. Because you didn't think I'd come.

Marc-Anthony closes his eyes.

MARC-ANTHONY
We didn't want to put you in a position where you'd have to say no.

DESMOND (V.O.)
Tell my daughter I'll walk her.

(beat)
Tell her I asked. Not you. I asked.

Marc-Anthony can't speak for a moment. He puts his hand over his eyes.

MARC-ANTHONY
(hoarse)
I'll tell her you asked.

DESMOND (V.O.)
Good.

(beat, gruff)
And get a better tie for the wedding. I'm not fixing it twice.

Click. The line goes dead.

Marc-Anthony sits on the porch step for a long time with the phone in his lap. Then he gets up, goes inside, and kneels down beside the couch. He touches Esther's shoulder. She stirs, opens her eyes.

ESTHER
(sleepy)
What's wrong? Who was that?

MARC-ANTHONY
(smiling through tears)
Your dad.

(beat)
He asked.

Esther's eyes go wide. She knows exactly what he means. She sits up so fast she nearly drops Emma, and she pulls him into her arms, the girls squashed between them, all four of them on the couch, as the fairy lights blink on the porch outside.

FADE OUT.

HEADLINES

SUPER: MONDAY, DECEMBER 2, 2013

BOX OFFICE MOJO - "THOR: THE DARK WORLD" (Donohue)

Domestic: $213.6M - International: $468.9M - Worldwide: $682.5M (and counting)

Already the highest-grossing THOR film; on pace to finish above $700M worldwide.

VARIETY - MONDAY, DECEMBER 2, 2013

MARVEL'S 2013: 'IRON MAN 3' AND 'THOR: THE DARK WORLD' COMBINE FOR NEARLY $1.9 BILLION; 'WINTER SOLDIER' TRAILER DROPS IN JANUARY

PEOPLE.COM - MONDAY, DECEMBER 2, 2013

SOURCES: DESMOND SMILLEY WILL WALK ESTHER DOWN THE AISLE

"He asked," says one person close to the family. "That's the part that matters. He asked." The wedding date remains a secret, and, sources say, so does the location. A San Diego hotel security guard who has an invitation declined to comment, then added, "My wife has a new dress."

TWITTER.COM - PUBLIC TIMELINE

SDMarriottGerald: people keep asking me when the wedding is. i've been holding doors for 30 years. i know how to keep one shut. 10:12 AM Dec 2nd from Twitter for Android

esthersmilley: he asked. 11:00 AM Dec 2nd from Twitter for iPhone

FADE OUT.

END OF CHAPTER EIGHTEEN